

Genuinely Why don't AI companies just use a different type of energy?

Posted by u/Sorincherrybomb • 0 points • 37 comments

Like solar. Wind idfk. Like I ask this question often but no one answers. Is it greed?(I wouldn't be surprised). Because I notice people's problem is the environment and I understand but like if AI companies didn't active fuck with the planet or cause people to act like they will die if they don't use it etc.I honestly wouldn't care as much

Comments

u/Alarming_Swan6270 • 1 points • 2026-02-04 16:05 UTC

****AI today is increasingly a physical industrial system.**** That means every step forward in capability puts bigger energy demands on the real world, not just on computers.

- **AI's growth drives massive computing needs**** Modern AI systems, especially large models and data-intensive applications, require huge amounts of computing power. That power comes from **data centres** that run servers constantly, not just occasionally. These centres aren't small offices; they operate like industrial facilities consuming ****tens to hundreds of megawatts of continuous power****.
- **Data centres use electricity like heavy industry**** In Europe alone, data centre energy use is already a significant share of total electricity demand, and globally it's projected to grow substantially over this decade. The hardware, cooling systems and electrical infrastructure all consume vast amounts of energy.
- **Physical infrastructure drives energy demand**** It's not just the CPUs/GPUs inside servers; AI infrastructure requires:
 - * Power grids capable of supplying sustained, high-load electricity*
 - * Cooling systems to prevent overheating*
 - * Electrical networks and transformers. All of this adds layers of energy consumption that go **beyond** the processors doing computation.*
- **Materials and industrial scale matter.**** Building and expanding this kind of capacity also depends on energy-intensive materials like copper, steel and other components in data centres and grid infrastructure, further linking AI's growth to overall energy consumption and supply constraints.

<https://financialintelligence.ro/ian-timis-despre-agenda-globala-a-ai-ului-mineralelor-critice-si-tranzitiei-energetice-cand-capitalul-intalneste-constrangerea/>

u/Dave_A480 • 2 points • 2026-01-18 01:22 UTC

Any given energy source has to be converted to electricity in order to be useful for powering computers.

It is much more economical to get electricity from the open market than it is to build 'for AI use only' power plants using any given technology.....

People's problem with AI is that they are luddites. The environmental part is just an excuse....

u/Interesting-Card5803 • 2 points • 2026-01-14 19:53 UTC

The answer is that they do. There's just not enough of it to meet demand. They broker in power that is sustainably produced with utility companies. I've seen them utilize/purchase solar, wind, hydroelectric, biomass generation, and nuclear. They will also utilize utility grade recycled water if the jurisdictions offer it.

But given the scale of power demand, solar and wind direct to the facility just won't cut it. You'd need so much land to do it, it's almost impossible for these companies.

u/Sorincherrybomb • 1 points • 2026-01-14 23:53 UTC

Mm okay thank you for telling!

u/sudoku7 • 2 points • 2026-01-14 19:46 UTC

Generally speaking, data centers are on the public grid. They don't have their own power plants (they certainly do have backup generators but those aren't the primary power draw). They take power from the public grid, and while they can say they are buying "green power" it is largely diluted by the time of consumption. The generation still needs to happen, and the increased power demands are going to require additional generation capacity, and require it very fast.

u/KronusIV • 1 points • 2026-01-14 14:17 UTC

You want your servers running 24/7. Solar and wind don't provide power all the time. The data centers would happily take that power, but they'd need something in addition for nighttime, or when there's no wind.

u/Mediocre_Ad_9153 • 1 points • 2026-01-14 14:10 UTC

Solar and wind doesn't generate enough energy to power AI that's why I think uranium is going to be the next big thing since it's gonna take nuclear power plants to power AI, in addition I don't support oil since US is taking it from other countries

u/PurplesunsetBluelips • 3 points • 2026-01-14 14:06 UTC

My understanding also is that the water is for cooling all of these server rooms because they get really really hot. Before AI, server rooms for hospitals had to basically be air-conditioned, which uses water.

u/TortieTactics • 2 points • 2026-01-14 14:05 UTC

same reasons you don't grow your own food

u/Sorincherrybomb • 1 points • 2026-01-14 14:06 UTC

I have grown my own food... 🧑🌾

u/TortieTactics • 1 points • 2026-01-14 14:07 UTC

and, why don't you solely grow your own food now?

u/Sorincherrybomb • 1 points • 2026-01-14 14:07 UTC

It's winter time 😞

u/TortieTactics • 3 points • 2026-01-14 14:12 UTC

that doesnt mean you can't grow your own food. it means it's inconvenient, more expensive, etc.

grab yourself some tents, lights, ventilation, air treatment, and you're all set.

same reasons a data center might give for buying power off the grid.

datacenters have backup power, it just cost more to use than grid.

u/Sorincherrybomb • 1 points • 2026-01-14 15:06 UTC

All hehes than you for answering!